

Week 13: Contemporary Canada: Crisis, Technology, Environment, and the Future

As we conclude this course, we shift our attention to the challenges and opportunities facing contemporary Canada. Today's writers examine how personal lives intersect with broader issues such as environmental change, digital technology, public perception, and uncertainty about the future. Rather than presenting these topics as abstract concepts, contemporary fiction explores how ordinary people experience them in their daily lives.

This Week's Reading

"Pack Ice Season" by Bridget Canning — a story set in Newfoundland where a community is transformed by the arrival of a massive iceberg.

The Central Tension

While the community sees a miraculous image of Jesus Christ, the protagonist Joni McEntaggart sees the face of her late husband, Gerard, who disappeared at sea.

The Core Insight

People interpret the same event in profoundly different ways, shaped by **personal history**, memory, emotion, and individual experience.

Contemporary Canadian Literature and a Changing Society

Contemporary Canadian literature reflects a society that continues to evolve in response to social, technological, environmental, and cultural change. While earlier generations of Canadian writers often focused on settlement, survival, immigration, or national identity, many twenty-first-century authors examine the **uncertainties of modern life**. Climate change, digital communication, economic challenges, and rapidly changing communities have become important subjects in contemporary fiction.

Key Principle

Contemporary writers present situations in which **multiple perspectives coexist**, and no single interpretation fully explains what is happening. In *"Pack Ice Season,"* one extraordinary natural event becomes a source of hope, faith, economic opportunity, curiosity, and emotional pain — simultaneously.

Themes in Contemporary Canadian Fiction

- **Environmental change** — shifting landscapes and seasonal patterns
- **Digital communication** — social media and public perception
- **Economic uncertainty** — rural communities and tourism
- **Mental health and grief** — emotional complexity and healing
- **Community and place** — regional identity in a national context

What unites these works is not *what* they are about, but *how* they connect global issues to individual lives.

Technology, Media, and the Construction of Meaning

One of the most contemporary aspects of "**Pack Ice Season**" is its portrayal of digital communication. The iceberg becomes famous not simply because it appears in the bay, but because photographs and social media posts spread the image far beyond the local community — transforming a local curiosity into a widely shared online phenomenon.

The Photograph

Doug Prentice's image, shared with hashtags such as **#Jesus**, **#iceberg**, and **#icebergjesus**, attracts immediate online attention.

The Cultural Phenomenon

Technology does not create the iceberg, but it **transforms the iceberg** into a cultural and economic event far beyond its physical presence.

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The Viral Spread

News organizations, artists, religious leaders, and visitors all contribute to the growing public fascination with "Iceberg Jesus."

The Commercialization

Souvenirs, postcards, T-shirts, kayak tours, and food vendors appear — raising questions about commerce, meaning, and the sacred.

While thousands of people see a miraculous image, Joni sees something entirely different — shaped not by social media, but by her own painful memories. **Personal experience often influences perception more powerfully than popular narratives.**

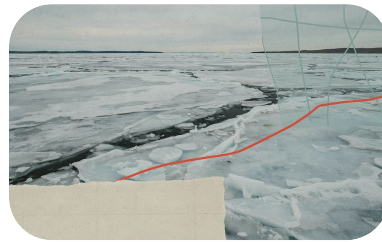
The Environment as More Than a Setting

The natural environment plays a central role throughout "**Pack Ice Season**." The iceberg, the pack ice, the sea, the fog, and the changing weather are not simply elements of the setting — they actively influence the characters' experiences and the direction of the story. This reflects a long tradition in Canadian literature, where landscapes often function as powerful symbols.



The Iceberg Arrives

The iceberg transforms everyday life — roads become crowded, businesses respond to increased tourism, and residents gather along the shoreline to witness an extraordinary event.



"Pack Ice Season"

A phrase promoted by the tourism department to encourage visitors to view the arrival of sea ice as a seasonal attraction — illustrating how communities **reshape public perception** of natural conditions.



Environment and Emotion

Ice accumulates around Joni's home, icicles form along the roof, and household tasks become more difficult — connecting the physical landscape directly with her internal struggles.

i The story suggests that people continually **negotiate the relationship between nature, culture, and economic survival** — a key theme in contemporary Canadian fiction.

Grief, Memory, and the Power of Perspective

At its heart, "**Pack Ice Season**" is a story about grief and the lasting effects of emotional trauma. While the community celebrates what many believe to be a miraculous sight, Joni experiences the iceberg as a painful reminder of her husband, Gerard, who disappeared at sea following an argument.

The Complexity of Joni's Grief

As readers learn more about Joni's memories, it becomes clear that her grief is complicated. Gerard's disappearance has left many unanswered questions, but the story also reveals that their marriage was marked by emotional control, criticism, and intimidation. Even after his disappearance, she continues to hear his voice in her thoughts, criticizing her decisions and making her doubt herself.

Canning carefully avoids portraying grief as a simple or predictable process. Joni experiences sadness, relief, guilt, anger, fear, and uncertainty — sometimes all at once. These conflicting emotions make her character realistic and remind readers that healing rarely follows a straight path.

A Defining Emotional Journey

Rather than presenting grief as something that can simply be overcome, the story suggests that healing involves learning to **live with painful memories** while gradually reclaiming one's independence and identity.

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Grief and Emotional Paralysis

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Resilience and Reclaimed Identity

Symbolism and Literary Techniques

One of the greatest strengths of **"Pack Ice Season"** is its rich use of symbolism. Throughout the story, ordinary objects and natural elements carry deeper meanings that help readers understand Joni's emotional journey. Reading the story is fundamentally an **interpretive and participatory act**.



The Iceberg

For the community: **"Iceberg Jesus"** — hope, faith, miracles. For Joni: the face of Gerard. The iceberg never changes, but its meaning changes depending on who is looking at it.



The Pack Ice

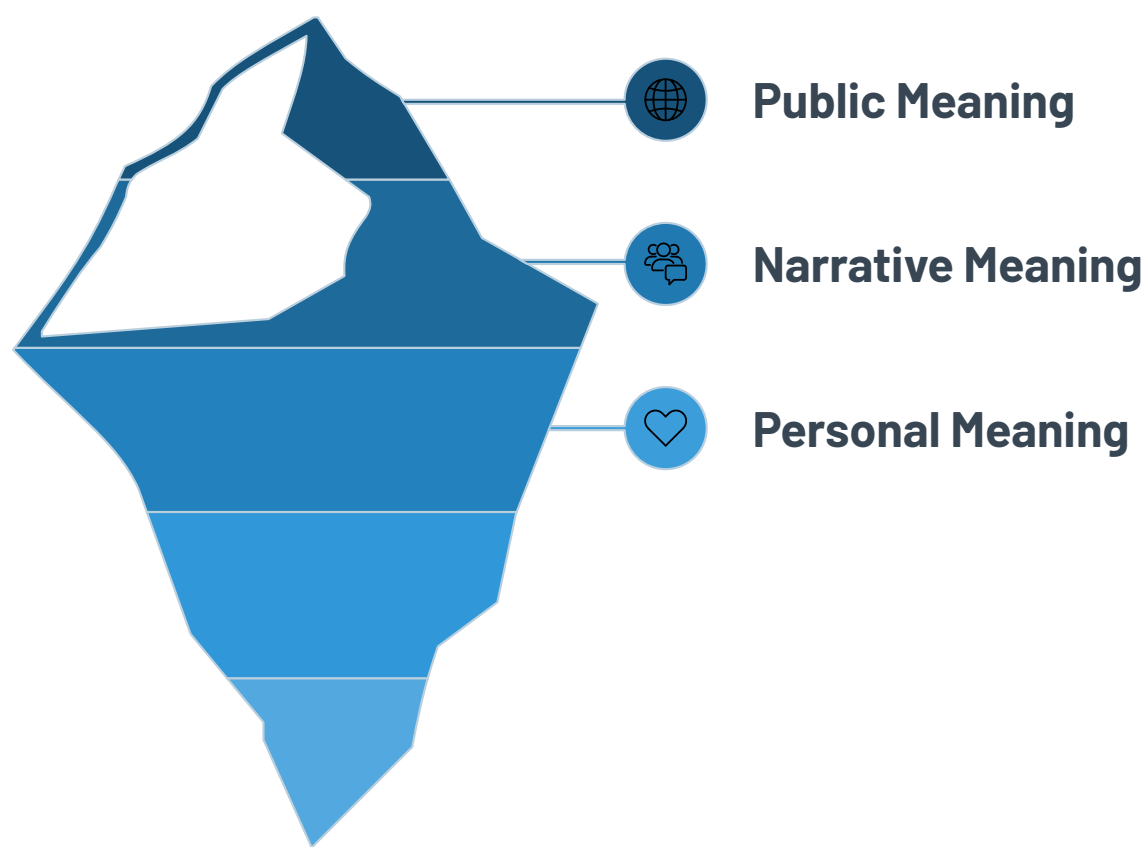
It traps the iceberg within the bay, just as Joni feels trapped by her memories. When the pack ice begins to break apart, emotional healing may also begin — a subtle and powerful parallel.



Shane the Cat

Represents companionship and emotional security. When Shane disappears and returns injured, his experience mirrors Joni's own wounds — both have survived, but both carry lasting scars.

Consider: The same iceberg is photographed thousands of times. For most viewers, it represents a miracle. For Joni, looking at it from her home, it is an unavoidable symbol of unresolved loss. This understanding is not given directly — it is **constructed through the reader's engagement with the text**.



Unlike simpler narratives, *"Pack Ice Season"* relies on the reader to bridge multiple layers of meaning — making reading a deeply participatory and interpretive act.

Looking Back on the Course & Key Takeaways

As we conclude our study of Canadian short fiction, "**Pack Ice Season**" brings together many of the themes explored throughout the semester — identity, family, belonging, Indigenous perspectives, immigration, community, memory, and the relationship between people and place — while introducing new concerns related to technology, environmental change, tourism, and public perception.

What This Story Demonstrates

- Literature connects global issues with individual lives through intimate human experience
- Multiple perspectives coexist — no single interpretation fully explains an event
- Place, community, and environment actively shape character and theme in Canadian fiction

Enduring Questions from the Course

- **Identity** — how do individuals define themselves within communities?
- **Resilience** — how do people adapt during times of uncertainty and loss?
- **Perception** — how does personal history shape the way we interpret the world?
- **Technology** — how does digital media reshape collective meaning and memory?
- **Place** — how does landscape shape emotional and cultural experience?

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